PRD-02 · Interview loops, rounds and feedback

Status: Shipped (v0.1.2) · **Updated:** 2026-10-30 · **Design:** DD-02 Interview engine, DD-01 AI brain

1. Summary

A **loop** is a set of rounds run in order, like a real onsite. Each **round** is a live conversation with one interviewer persona, a clock, and a workspace. After each round the candidate gets a **report**. After the loop they get a **verdict** from a simulated hiring committee.

2. User stories

Id	As a…	I want to…	So that…
LOOP-S1	candidate	pick the rounds, company style, level and interviewer style	practice matches the job I'm going for
LOOP-S2	candidate	be interviewed by a consistent persona with a real voice and habits	it feels like a person, not a chat bot
LOOP-S3	candidate	have the interviewer follow up, push back and keep time	I train for real pressure
LOOP-S4	candidate	get a report with scores and evidence after each round	I know exactly what to fix
LOOP-S5	candidate	get a hire / no-hire verdict after the loop	I know if I'm ready
LOOP-S6	candidate	see my skill scores over time and what to practise next	I can plan the next week
LOOP-S7	candidate	not hear the same opening question every time	repeated practice stays useful

3. The setup screen

The *Interviews* screen walks through five numbered steps. The right side shows the loop as a timeline.



Choices

Setting	Options	Source
Mode	General practice · Company-specific (needs a dossier, see PRD-04)	UI
Company style	14: *Infer from the JD*, Google, Amazon, Meta, Microsoft, Apple, Netflix, Uber, Stripe, Atlassian, Flipkart, Indian fintech, Bank tech, Funded startup	`catalog.json` → `COMPANIES`
Interviewer style (temperament)	Supportive (hints when stuck) · Realistic (neutral, like a real panel) · Bar-raiser (terse, skeptical, rarely hints)	`TEMPER`
Interviewers	Mixed (a different named interviewer each round) · Indian Tech Panel · International Tech Panel	`panels.json`
Level	New grad · SDE-1 · SDE-2 · Senior · Staff	`LEVELS`, with a written bar per level in `LEVEL_BAR`
Coding language	Java, Python, C++, JavaScript, TypeScript, Go	UI
Round length	Real length per round, or 10 / 20 / 30 minutes each	UI
Resume	Required. PDF, Word, RTF, text. Runs the resume check first (PRD-05).	UI
Job description	Optional, same formats	UI
Additional details	Free text to the panel, e.g. "Weak at DP"	UI

4. Round types

Key	Round	Real length	Default tab	Rubric dimensions
`resume`	Resume screen	30 min	Notes	Clarity of story · Depth behind claims · Role fit · Motivation · Communication
`project`	Project deep dive	45	Notes (+ Whiteboard)	Ownership · Technical depth · Trade-off reasoning · Impact and metrics · Communication
`fundamentals`	Technical fundamentals	45	Notes	Accuracy · Depth · Applied reasoning · Communication
`coding`	DSA coding	45	Editor	Problem solving · Code quality · Testing and edge cases · Complexity analysis · Communication
`comprehension`	Code comprehension and review	45	From interviewer	Reading accuracy · Bug finding · Prioritisation and judgment · Fix quality · Testing mindset · Communication
`lld`	Low-level design	60	Notes (+ Whiteboard)	Requirements · Object modelling · Code quality and SOLID · Extensibility · Concurrency
`sysdesign`	System design	60	Notes (+ Whiteboard)	Requirements and scoping · Architecture · Deep dive · Scale and reliability · Trade-offs · Driving the discussion
`behavioral`	Behavioral	45	Notes	Specificity · Ownership · Self-awareness · Collaboration and conflict · Values alignment
`hm`	Hiring manager	45	Notes	Scope and impact · Judgment · Team fit · Motivation · Quality of their questions

Each round in `catalog.json` also has a **guide** (how to run it, sent to the interviewer) and **openers** (starting points that rotate, see LOOP-R7). The coding round has no openers: the question bank picks the problem.

The room shows a **round plan** for the candidate. Example for coding: Introduction 7% · Problem and clarifying questions 13% · Approach and complexity 17% · Code it 38% · Dry run, edge cases, follow-up 18% · Your questions 7%.

5. Interviewer personas

Two panels ship in `prompts/panels.json`, five interviewers each:

Indian Tech Panel	International Tech Panel
Arjun Mehta, Engineering Manager	Ethan Brooks, Principal Engineer / Architect
Neha Kapoor, Senior Technical Recruiter / HR	Olivia Chen, Technical Recruiter / HR
Karthik Reddy, Senior Technical Interviewer	Marcus Reed, Senior Technical Interviewer
Vikram Desai, Staff Engineer / Domain Specialist	Priya Shah, Staff Engineer / Domain Expert
Sameer Khanna, Director of Engineering	Daniel Foster, Engineering Manager

Each persona has traits, a communication style, a strictness (1–5), a backstory, the round types they own, a speaking-speed factor and a **voice design** (an instruction to VoiceStudio). The voice is built once per persona and stays the same every round.

> **Rule:** when the chosen temperament and the persona's strictness disagree, the temperament wins for *how often to hint and how warm to sound*. The persona keeps its identity, habits and standards.

6. Requirements

Id	Requirement	Status
LOOP-R1	The interviewer speaks in short turns (1–4 sentences), one question at a time, with no markdown in speech.	Shipped (prompt rule)
LOOP-R2	The interviewer paces the round from `[Elapsed: X of Y min]` on every candidate message, starts wrapping up at ~85%, and leaves time for the candidate's questions.	Shipped
LOOP-R3	The interviewer closes the round itself and marks it with `[[END]]`. The app then shows "Get my feedback".	Shipped
LOOP-R4	No feedback, scores or praise during the round ("never say great answer").	Shipped (prompt rule)
LOOP-R5	Code the interviewer shows goes to the workspace ("From interviewer" tab), not into speech.	Shipped
LOOP-R6	The candidate's editor and whiteboard reach the interviewer when changed, inside a `[Workspace]` block.	Shipped
LOOP-R7	Opening variety: each round gets an opener not used recently, and the openings of the last 4 rounds of that type as "do not reuse".	Shipped
LOOP-R8	Only one round runs at a time. Starting a new one closes any round left open.	Shipped

Id	Requirement	Status
LOOP-R9	A round with no answers is deleted, so history only lists rounds that happened.	Shipped
LOOP-R10	Terminate = stop now, no feedback, nothing saved (typed confirmation "terminate").	Shipped
LOOP-R11	A report needs at least 2 answers and 40 words. Otherwise: "Not enough to review yet."	Shipped
LOOP-R12	If the interviewer process dies mid-round, the next answer reconnects to the same conversation.	Shipped (CLI: `--resume`; API: history in memory)
LOOP-R13	Interviews are in English only. Accented speech mis-heard as Spanish is read as English.	Shipped

7. The round report

Generated by the *report model* with no tools, from `prompts/report.md`. Sample (shortened):

```
{
  "overall": 68,
  "decision": "Lean hire",
  "level_signal": "Near SDE-2 bar",
  "headline": "Solid hash-map approach and clean code; weak on edge cases and complexity
proof.",
  "dimensions": [
    {"name": "Problem solving", "score": 3, "evidence": "Moved from O of n squared to a single
pass after one nudge."},
    {"name": "Testing and edge cases", "score": 2, "evidence": "Did not test an empty array
until asked."}
  ],
  "went_well": ["Asked about duplicates before coding"],
  "held_back": ["Stated complexity without explaining why"],
  "fix_first": "Before coding, list three edge cases out loud and say how the code handles
each.",
  "moments": [{"question": "What if the array is huge?", "said": "Use a bigger hash map.",
"better": "Discuss memory, streaming, and sorting plus two pointers."}],
  "practice_next": ["Two-pointer problems", "Explaining amortised complexity"]
}
```

- **Decision scale:** Strong hire · Hire · Lean hire · Lean no hire · No hire.
- **Dimension scores:** 1–4, or null when the round gave no signal.
- **Measured facts** are given to the model so it cannot invent them: number of answers, average words, longest answer, planned vs actual minutes.

- **Speech-to-text leniency:** garbled answers are judged on intent; the report may note a possible transcription problem.

8. The loop verdict

After a loop, `loop_feedback` writes any missing round reports. Once **two or more rounds** have a report, it asks for a committee decision from `prompts/verdict.md`:

```
{
  "decision": "Hire at lower level",
  "rationale": "Strong coding and fundamentals. System design needed heavy guidance…",
  "strongest_signal": "Payments idempotency deep dive",
  "biggest_risk": "Could not drive the design discussion",
  "plan": ["Practise 3 design problems end to end with estimates", "…"]
}
```

Decisions: Hire · No hire · Hire at lower level · Borderline — more data needed.

9. Dashboard

Everything is computed in the UI from `history` (each row carries the round key, minutes and report JSON). No numbers are faked; an empty history shows empty states.

Widget	What it shows	Rule
Continue	Review or get feedback on the last round	Last round in history
Weekly goal	Rounds per week, per round type	`weekly_goal` setting
Skill scores	Average 1–4 per rubric dimension	Grouped by dimension name across reports
Trend	Overall score over time	Sparkline per reviewed round
Practise next	Weakest skills	Needs a skill low in **2+ rounds**
Highlights	Strongest skills	Needs a skill high in **2+ rounds**
Recent interviews	Last few rounds	History

10. Out of scope / open

- **Comprehension round redesign** (Planned): today the interviewer writes the code to review. Options under study: curated small repos, bug datasets (Defects4J, BugsInPy), mutation tools. See `docs/comprehension-round-research.md`.

- **Difficulty picker** for coding (today: New grad → Easy, Senior/Staff → Hard, else Medium).
- **Pausing a round** and coming back later.